

with the people. For nationalists, these spaces became ideal venues where they could mobilize crowds or even ask for money to fund movements. The Criminal Investigation Department (CID) and railway police would often wait for leaders travelling to a location for a demonstration and arrest them as soon as they got off the train. The national leaders, however, were well aware that an enthusiastic crowd could easily become an unruly mob and often implored people to follow station etiquette, be mindful of other passengers, and avoid shouting slogans until the train had actually arrived at the station.

At the height of the Quit India movement (1942), students used the railways as a way to communicate. In Bihar, trains were covered with the National Flag and carriages inscribed with slogans. Nationalists encouraged third-class travellers to use first-class compartments and there were even reports that those wearing Western clothes were not allowed to board trains.

As the country inched towards Independence, the people and their national leaders had appropriated the railways making it a key part of the freedom movement.